

Music from Scratch

If you really want to get down to the basics, right to creating your own tunes from scratch, then you should head to www.neuralsemantics.com and try out their e-guitar Robocaster. It's a cross between an e-guitar and an e-piano and you can use your mouse to play notes on the piano keyboard or drag your mouse over the guitar string to pluck notes on the e-recorder's virtual guitar.

The Robocaster e-



recorder has an internal volume regulator that's independent of your PC's volume control. You can also use the controls on the recorder to create electric guitar distortion effects or create sound freaks. You can use the 'scaler' to customise your piano keys. Just enter the notes to get the keyboard of your choice. You can record your composition and save your masterpieces on the Neuralsemantics server.

The e-recorder runs smoothly, loads in no time (even if you have a slow connection), and is fairly easy to use. However, you need a basic knowledge of music notations to be able to use it effectively. But if you are really interested in picking up the basics of reading musical notes, check out www.learn2.com/09/0917/0917.asp. This site has a good step-by-step tutorial too.

music types using the keys on your computer's keyboard. The site has five different genres of music you can choose, from techno to jazz. Just hit a few keys to create a sound or a rhythm, accompanied by animated graphics.

Each section tells you what keys to hit for orchestra loops, drum or guitar solos along with useful tips and key combinations to help you create your unique mix. While the Graphic Piano lets you mix rhythms and tracks, you can't save what you've created. A version of the Graphic Piano is also available at the Beatles Web site (www.thebeatles.com/lovedemo/treatment/), where you can create your own 'Love me do' animation.

The Nike site at http://play.nike.com/play/mix_it.jsp?cityid=4 is similar to the Graphic Piano but it also lets you record and mail your mixes to your friends.

If you're still new to the 'ebony and ivory' of the piano, then here's where you can get up close, online: <http://www.pianoworld.com/fun/javapiano/javapiano.htm> loads a small Java electronic piano onto your screen, which you can play by clicking on the black and white keys with your mouse, to the accompaniment of drumbeats. You can listen to a few demo tunes and also record your own.

Hey, Mr DJ...

Want your own version of Britney's 'Oops! I did it again', in just a few minutes? You can remix popular singles released by a selected number of artists at <http://www.shockwave.com>. Head to the Create and Send section of the site to try your hand

at the 'Mixmaker'. You'll have to download a plugin from Beatnik (www.beatnik.com) for the Mixmaker to work. Mixes created here can also be recorded and sent by e-mail.

SSEYO, a company that develops music creation tools for desktops, handhelds and the Web, has three versions of an online music mixer called FreeMixer, powered by the popular Koan Internet audio engine and Flash. Of these three versions of FreeMixer, one makes MP3s (www.sseyo.com/products/webapps/freemixer/mp31/freemixer1.html), one is a general MIDI mixer (www.sseyo.com/products/webapps/freemixer/gm1/freemixer1.html), and the last is an XG MIDI mixer (www.sseyo.com/products/webapps/freemixer/xg1/freemixer1.html).

FreeMixer allows you to create original pieces of music that can be constructed from tiny MP3 samples, typically around 2 kb to 20 kb in size—rather like musical building blocks. Aside from using it for free, you can even put FreeMixer on your own Web site. It also has an option that lets you publish your mix online.

Some of the best online mixers can be found at www.ss7x7.com/mixers. The site has four extremely good online mixers: the Db-7x7 that only plays the SS7x7 interactive music format, the 7x7 Studio that has more tweaking options, the 7x7 Probemix that you can add on to your Web page and the Db-707 Synth, an online 3D synthesizer keyboard.

First time users can start with the basic Db-7x7 mixer, which is the easiest to use. This mixer

A Studio in Cyberspace

Efforts at getting musicians located anywhere in the world to collaborate and work online don't just end at mixing music and jamming over the Net. Rocket Network (www.rocketnet-work.com), a company that develops software and services to facilitate professional audio collaboration over the Internet has teamed up with Harmony Central and EMagic to launch an online recording studio, the only one of its kind on the Net.

With the online studio, Rocket Network hopes to create a virtual workplace with powerful communication capabilities, which is cost-effective and a convenient complement to traditional studios.

To access the online studio, you need a PC or a Mac with an audio and/or MIDI interface and a Net connection. You also need to download the Logic Rocket and Rocket control, software that will enable you to use the studio online. The software is available for free at www.harmony-central.com/rocket. However, Logic Control will work only with Windows 95 or 98

and not with Windows 2000 or XP.

Once installed, you need to launch both Logic Rocket and Rocket Control to connect to the studio. You can use Logic Rocket to create, record and post audio and MIDI tracks to everyone in the studio, while Rocket Control lets you locate users, navigate between studios online and chat with users within studios through a Web interface.

Use the Web interface to browse through public studios or 'studio centres' such as EMagic Pro or the Musicians.com studio centre. You have a choice of about seven studio centres, which you can join on a per session basis.

You can download the project that's being worked on in a particular studio, use the audio software to create tracks, contribute your track to the project and share it with other users in the studio.

You can join any of the public studios for free but if you want a private studio and want to work with selected users and save sessions, you'll need to pay to use it.